

Dvar Torah Outline — Hallel (Psalm 118): “עָזִי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה,” the Power of Praise, and Hodaa as Devekut

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman continues learning the Maharal's explanation of Hallel (פרק סד), focusing on the pasuk “עָזִי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה לִי לִישׁוּעָה” and how its grammar shapes its meaning. He develops a theme that praise and song from צדיקים “add strength,” כביכול, by opening channels for Divine revelation—linking this to the Ramchal's framing of “עלינו לשבח.” Rabbi Shulman then pivots to several pesukim in the same chapter about שְׁעָרִים, יסורים, and הודאה, presenting hodaa not only as gratitude but as admission/acknowledgment that creates דביקות by returning one's “ownership” back to Hashem.

I. Setting the sugya: continuing in Hallel, פרק סד

A. Focus on the Maharal's reading of a key pasuk

- The discussion centers on the pasuk:
 - “עָזִי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה לִי לִישׁוּעָה” (*My strength and song is God, and He was for me a salvation.*)
- Rabbi Shulman flags that the Maharal is being precise about:
 - ניקוד (vowelization),
 - whether the phrase is possessive (“my strength”) or descriptive (“strength”),
 - and what the phrase “וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה לִי לִישׁוּעָה” refers back to.

B. “וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה” vs. “עָזִי”: tense nuance and what it modifies

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - “וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה” implies an ongoing/imperfect past (as opposed to a simple finished past).
- Core interpretive claim:
 - “וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה לִי לִישׁוּעָה” goes back to **Hashem**, not to “strength and song” as independent forces.

C. Why “עָזִי” is not “עָזִי”: the Maharal's dikduk point

- Rabbi Shulman reports the Maharal's point:
 - “עָזִי” is written with a קמץ; if it meant “my strength” in the possessive sense, it would be “עָזִי” (with a קבוץ).

- Supporting comment from Rashi (as cited by Rabbi Shulman):
 - The ם is understood as an “extra” intensifier rather than a possessive suffix.

D. “וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה” vs. “וְזִמְרַתִּי”: not “my song”

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's reading:
 - The pasuk does **not** say “וְזִמְרַתִּי ה'” (“my song is Hashem”).
 - Instead: “וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה” is “the song of Hashem” (a construct form / סמיכות).
- Rabbi Shulman notes an unresolved difficulty:
 - How exactly the phrase is being read to yield: “Hashem was to me strength/song/salvation,” and he marks this paragraph as still not fully clear to him.

II. “קול רְנָה וְיִשׁוּעָה”: how song of צדיקים ‘adds strength’ Above (5:00)

A. The Maharal's theme: praise below empowers revelation above

- Text in focus:
 - “קול רְנָה וְיִשׁוּעָה בְּאֵלֵי צַדִּיקִים” (*The voice of song and salvation is in the tents of the righteous.*)
- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal:
 - When צדיקים sing/praise in their tents, **they** “add כביכול”, כוח וגבורה למעלה—a metaphoric way of saying that human recognition of Hashem activates Divine influence in the world.

B. Link to Ramchal: “עלינו לשבח” as a spiritual mechanism

- Rabbi Shulman parallels this to the Ramchal's approach:
 - First paragraph: **our role is praise** (“עלינו לשבח”).
 - Second paragraph: **therefore** (“על כן נקוו לך”) we anticipate Hashem's greater revelation.
- He frames it as:
 - Our praise “opens pipelines/portals” that allow Divine strength to manifest.

C. Proof-text idea: “תנו עז לאלקים”

- Rabbi Shulman cites the concept:
 - “תנו עז לאלקים” (*Give strength to God.*)
- He emphasizes “so to speak” (כביכול):
 - Not literal strengthening of Hashem, but a description of how recognition below draws down השפעה.

III. "יָמִין ה' עֲשֶׂה חֵיל" / רִמְמָה: three "worlds" and a seeming redundancy (8:37)

A. The repeated pesukim and the question they raise

- Rabbi Shulman points to the repetition:
 - "יָמִין ה' עֲשֶׂה חֵיל" (*The right hand of Hashem performs might.*)
 - "יָמִין ה' רִמְמָה יָמִין ה' עֲשֶׂה חֵיל" (*The right hand of Hashem is exalted; the right hand of Hashem performs might.*)
- He notes the basic difficulty:
 - Why repeat "יָמִין ה' עֲשֶׂה חֵיל" twice, and why does only the middle phrase shift to "רִמְמָה"?

B. Maharal's structure: Hashem's "right hand" over three worlds

- Rabbi Shulman presents the Maharal's idea:
 - Hashem's "יָמִין" is described as extending over **שלוש עולמות**.
- Mapping suggested:
 1. **Lower realm (עולם התחתון)**: "יָמִין ה' עֲשֶׂה חֵיל" manifests in our world.
 2. **Heavens (מרום / שמים)**: "יָמִין ה' רִמְמָה" corresponds to "מרום."
 - Rabbi Shulman connects this to the נוסח in קדיש:
 - "בְּשָׁמַי מְרוֹמָא" (*in the heavens above*).
 3. **Upper realm (עולם העליון)**: again described as "יָמִין ה' עֲשֶׂה חֵיל."

C. Rabbi Shulman's open question

- He flags what remains unclear to him:
 - Why the **same** wording ("עֲשֶׂה חֵיל") is used for both the lowest and highest realms, while the middle realm (שמים) receives distinct language ("רִמְמָה").
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IV. “לֹא אָמוּת כִּי אֶחְיֶה”: living in order to speak of Hashem’s deeds (11:01)

A. Text and theme: desire for life as a vehicle for Kiddush Hashem

- Pesukim in focus:
 - “לֹא אָמוּת כִּי אֶחְיֶה וְאֶסְפֹּר מַעֲשֵׂי יְהוָה” (*I will not die, for I will live, and I will recount the deeds of God.*)
- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - דוד’s request is not simple self-preservation;
 - he wants life **in order to tell over Hashem’s deeds**.

B. “יִסֹּר יִסְרֵנִי יְהוָה וְלֹמֹות לֹא נִתְּנִי”: suffering without destruction

- Rabbi Shulman frames it as a praise within Hallel:
 - Even if יסורים are deserved, Hashem exacts דין in a merciful way—**not to the point of death**.

C. “דִּין שֶׁל רַחֲמִים”: through installments

- Rabbi Shulman uses the “installments” model:
 - Mercy does not erase דין; it can be paid gradually over time (even across generations).
- He ties it to the idea of:
 - “פֶּקֶד עֲוֹן אֲבוֹת עַל בְּנֵים... עַל שְׁלֹשִׁים וְעַל רְבָעִים” (*visiting the iniquity of fathers upon children... to the third and fourth generations*)—as a form of non-destructive דין.

V. “פֶּתַח לִי שַׁעַר צֶדֶק”: שַׁעַר צֶדֶק as entry to the transcendent world (14:00)

A. Identifying “שַׁעַר צֶדֶק”

- Pasuk in focus:
 - “פֶּתַח לִי שַׁעַר צֶדֶק” (*Open for me the gates of righteousness.*)
- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal’s definition:
 - This refers to an “עוֹלָם הַמּוֹבָדֵל”—a transcendent realm (potentially aligned with גן עדן),
 - called “gates of righteousness” because **there everything is truly just/fair**, unlike the ambiguities of this world.

B. Entering in order to give thanks and “complete” oneself toward Hashem

- Pasuk continuation:
 - “אֲבֹא בָם אוֹדָה יְהוָה” (*I will enter them; I will thank God.*)
 - Rabbi Shulman explains the phrase (in Maharal's language):
 - **Hodaa** here means:
 - expressing gratitude,
 - acknowledging Hashem,
 - and “וְאֶשְׁלֵם עִצְמִי אֶל ה'”—giving oneself over fully to Hashem.
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VI. Hodaa as admission: the mechanism of דְּבִיקוּת (15:01)

A. Connection to Maharal in נתיבות עולם (Netiv HaHodaah / discussion in Birkat HaMazon)

- Rabbi Shulman points to a related Maharal discussion:
 - In ברכת המזון, on “נוֹדָה לךְ”, on נתיבות עולם פרק יח.
- The shared thesis:
 - Thanks/admission is the pathway to דְּבִיקוּת.

B. Why gratitude creates דְּבִיקוּת (Rabbi Shulman's example)

- Rabbi Shulman explains the logic:
 - If I view what I have as “mine,” I stand as independent.
 - When I thank you, I'm admitting: **it came from you**; therefore, in a sense, it still “belongs” to you.
- Applied to Hashem:
 - When we thank Hashem for everything, we return “ownership” back to Him,
 - and that return/ביטול creates דְּבִיקוּת—not standing as an independent, standalone existence.

C. “זֶה הַשַּׁעַר לֵה'”: why צדיקים enter

- Pasuk in focus:
 - “זֶה הַשַּׁעַר לֵה' צְדִיקִים יָבֹאוּ בוֹ” (*This is the gate to Hashem; the righteous will enter it.*)
- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - צדיקים, who already live with an orientation toward the transcendent (עולם העליון),

- naturally “belong” to this gate because they possess that דביקות.

VII. “אוֹדֶה כִּי עֲנִיתִנִּי”: two kinds of thanksgiving in Hallel (18:30)

A. The question: didn’t we already say “הודו” earlier?

- Rabbi Shulman notes the textual issue:
 - Hallel already emphasized thanking Hashem earlier (e.g., “הודו לה’ כִּי טוֹב”),
 - so why return here with “אוֹדֶה כִּי עֲנִיתִנִּי”?

B. Maharal’s distinction: prevented suffering vs. being extracted from suffering

- Rabbi Shulman presents the answer:
 1. Earlier “הודו” = thanking Hashem for a צרה that was approaching but from which one was saved before it fully arrived.
 2. Here = thanking Hashem when one was **already inside** the צרה and was then taken out.

C. Rabbi Shulman’s note on proof

- He observes an additional point:
 - The phrase “כִּי עֲנִיתִנִּי” itself seems to indicate affliction already occurred—so the proof might be embedded directly in the word “עֲנִיתִנִּי.”
- The transcript ends as Rabbi Shulman notes they are approaching:
 - “אָבֵן מֵאֲסוֹ הַבּוֹנִים” (*The stone the builders despised...*) and the continuation of the chapter.

In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman uses the Maharal’s dikduk to show that “עֲזִי וְזִמְרַת יְהוָה” is not “my strength/my song,” but a declaration about **Hashem’s strength and song** and how salvation is attributed to Him.
- Praise from צדיקים—“קוֹל רִנָּה וְשׁוּעָה”—is portrayed as activating Divine influence, echoed by the Ramchal’s structure in “עלינו לשבח.”
- The repeated phrases “...יְמִין ה’” are read as describing Hashem’s presence across multiple “worlds,” though Rabbi Shulman highlights remaining questions about the formulation.
- Hodaa is developed as more than gratitude: it is **acknowledgment/admission** that returns one’s sense of ownership to Hashem and thereby creates דביקות.